prized possession of my childhood. It's where I have always seemed to score runs and play reasonably well, and it's where they would always arrange a braai for the players at lunch on the Sunday of the Test match, serving steaks and chops – by far the best food on the South African cricket circuit.

It's also home to the Titans, the provincial franchise that provided me with an important break in the game soon after leaving school, and to which I remain affiliated all these years later.

The unavoidable reality in South Africa is that playing for the national team means you will have very few, if any, opportunities to play for your franchise, and it's a pity I have been such an absentee in recent years. Jacques Faul, the Titans CEO, is one of the brightest cricket administrators in the country and, in years to come, when I have time, I look forward to giving something back to the organisation that first gave me a chance.

Cape Town is generally acclaimed as one of the most beautiful cities in the world. I agree, which is why we bought an apartment in the Mother City. Table Mountain, Kirstenbosch, Clifton, The Twelve Apostles, Hout Bay, Boulders Beach can all be counted among the jewels of the Cape – alongside Newlands cricket ground, a place where exceptional natural beauty is matched by exceptional enthusiasm in the stands.

A full house at Newlands generates the most exhilarating atmosphere of any ground in South Africa and, for me, the New Year Test in the Cape is always the most enjoyable match of the year. The supporters are invariably impassioned and knowledgeable, which may partly explain why, as a team, the Proteas have tended to perform consistently well at Newlands in recent years.

Port Elizabeth should not be underrated. The Eastern Cape city is quiet and dignified, and St George's Park enjoys the distinction of having hosted not only the first cricket Test match played by South Africa but also the first rugby Test match played by the Springboks. These days, the resident brass band always ensures a fun atmosphere and the famous old